

Tax Credits You May Be Missing

Tax credits can mean thousands of dollars back — even if you owe no tax or didn't earn much. Many people miss them. Below are the big ones and how to claim them. Tick the box once you've checked each one.

⚠ BEFORE YOU START

Refundable credits can put money in your pocket even with little or no income — but only if you file a return. A free VITA preparer (see the Free Tax Filing guide) can make sure you get every credit.

1 Credits for Workers & Families

The biggest refundable credits — real cash back.

☐ Earned Income Tax Credit (EITC)

Worth up to ~\$8,000 for low-to-moderate-income workers. Many eligible people never claim it.

→ www.irs.gov/credits-deductions/individuals/earned-income-tax-credit-eitc

☐ Child Tax Credit

Up to \$2,200 per qualifying child, with part refundable. Check if you qualify.

→ www.irs.gov/credits-deductions/individuals/child-tax-credit

☐ Child & Dependent Care Credit

Helps cover the cost of child care or care for a dependent so you can work.

→ www.irs.gov/credits-deductions/individuals/child-and-dependent-care-credit-information

2 Credits for School & Learning

Education credits lower the cost of college and training.

☐ American Opportunity & Lifetime Learning Credits

Credits for college and continuing-education costs — for you or your kids.

→ www.irs.gov/credits-deductions/individuals/education-credits-aotc-llc

3 Credits for Savers & Home

Often-missed credits for retirement saving and energy upgrades.

☐ Saver's Credit

A credit just for putting money into a retirement account, if your income qualifies.

→ www.irs.gov/retirement-plans/plan-participant-employee/retirement-savings-contributions-savers-credit

☐ Energy Home Credits

Credits for certain energy-saving home improvements. Confirm current rules, as these change.

→ www.irs.gov/credits-deductions/home-energy-tax-credits

4 Claim Credits From Past Years

You may be able to get money from returns you didn't file.

☐ File Back Returns for Missed Refunds

You generally have up to 3 years to file and still claim a refund or credit. A free clinic or VITA site can help.

→ www.irs.gov/filing

⚠ WATCH OUT FOR

You don't need to pay anyone to "find" your credits — free VITA preparers and tax software apply them automatically. Be wary of preparers who invent credits you don't qualify for; that can trigger an audit.

★ A TIP THAT HELPS

Always file a tax return even if you didn't earn much or owe nothing — refundable credits like the EITC are only paid out if you file. It's often free money left on the table.

NEED HELP WHERE YOU LIVE?

Need help where you live?

This guide covers federal credits. For your state's credits and free help claiming them, use the personalized AI search or ask in the Questions area.

MY NOTES — WHO I CALLED, WHEN, AND WHAT THEY SAID
